

Cholera and other types of vibriosis: a story of human pandemics and oysters on the half shell.

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Vibrios are ubiquitous in the aquatic environment and are commonly present in or on shellfish and other seafood. A small subset of strains/species are able to cause human disease, including the cholera toxin-producing strains of *Vibrio cholerae* that are responsible for epidemic/pandemic cholera; thermostable direct hemolysin-producing strains of *Vibrio parahaemolyticus*; and *Vibrio vulnificus*, which can cause fulminant sepsis. Cholera outbreaks can be initiated by transmission of "epidemic" *V. cholerae* strains from their environmental reservoir to humans through seafood or other environmentally related food or water sources. "Nonepidemic" strains of *V. cholerae* and strains of other *Vibrio* species, including *V. parahaemolyticus* and *V. vulnificus*, are generally acquired by eating seafood (particularly raw oysters/oysters on the half shell). Although the primary clinical manifestation of infection with these strains is gastroenteritis, they can also cause wound infections and (particularly for *V. vulnificus*) septicemia in persons who have liver disease or are immunocompromised.